PEER REVIEW HISTORY

BMJ Open publishes all reviews undertaken for accepted manuscripts. Reviewers are asked to complete a checklist review form (**http://bmjopen.bmj.com/site/about/resources/checklist.pdf**) and are provided with free text boxes to elaborate on their assessment. These free text comments are reproduced below.

ARTICLE DETAILS

TITLE (PROVISIONAL)	Lessons from countries implementing find, test, trace, isolation and support policies in the rapid response of the COVID-19 pandemic: a systematic review
AUTHORS	Chung, Sheng-Chia; Marlow, Sushila; Tobias, Nick; Alogna, Allesio; Alogna, Ivano; You, San-Lin; Khunti, Kamlesh; McKee, Martin; Michie, Susan; Pillay, Deenan

VERSION 1 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Mariani, Javier GEDIC (Grupo de Estudio, Docencia e Investigaci&#65533;n Cl&#65533;nica)
REVIEW RETURNED	22-Dec-2020

GENERAL COMMENTS	Authors report a systematic review on the Find, Test, Trace, Isolation and Support (FTTIS) policies for COVID-19 response. The manuscript is extremely interesting, timely, and relevant because it summarizes all the information available on health systems strategies to respond to the pandemic, up to the time the literature search was performed. As the authors point out, this information could be useful for health planning. Furthermore, it is very clearly presented and comprehensive. The main concern that arises when reviewing the paper is that the search was carried out on May 28, the date on which 160 articles were found. Repeating the search strategy, according to the search terms and the type of article reported by the authors, on December 22, 1,290 articles were retrieved only in PubMed, and this included papers from regions of the world not contemplated in the current manuscript. and new information on aspects addressed in the review. Modifications in the epidemiological dynamics of the pandemic and in the adaptive responses of various regions of the world could enrich the knowledge for future measures, so it would be important to incorporate this new information into the review.

REVIEWER	Reintjes, Ralf Hamburg University of Applied Sciences, Health Sciences
REVIEW RETURNED	08-Jan-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	This is an interesting paper, even though it does not follow the standard structure of a research paper. Nevertheless, it is of interest for decision makers and the medical community. The major point I need to raise is, that the paper does not provide a discussion of its limitations. Thus a comprehensive discussion part should be added.

	In the methods section I was wondering why the literature review was limited 1.) to English language as a lot of potentially useful document will be missed and 2.) why it was limited to papers published between May 2019 and May 2020. Minor points: Page 3, line 37: correct to "NOT available" Page 4, line 7: at current it is questionable if high-risk settings still holds. Page 6, line 20/21: please correct the language Page 6, lines 38-50: these measures are used in various countries, not only in those mentioned, and often a combination of these.

REVIEWER	Ebrahim, Shahul University of Bamako
REVIEW RETURNED	11-Jan-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	Chung etal. A rapid systematic review…. A very useful and informative work on COVID-19 response. I comment the authors on undertaking this effort. Few suggestions to boost its readability from a customer's perspective. 1. I would suggest authors to reformat the abstract sections "Results" and "Conclusions" to provide some take home results and conclusions points for the reader. As it is written, for example the conclusion, "Results of the review may inform countries…" is not reassuring for the reader. Although the readers will ultimately weigh on what the authors are proposing, the authors should provide what they found and how it can impact policy. In the Results section of the abstract it says, "we reported optimal strategies to shorten….", rather a quick reader is looking for what exactly are those. Please remember, many readers would just read the abstract and decide if they want to read further. Therefore, make the bait in the abstract more inviting. 2. The above comment applies also to the conclusions in page 10. Rather than telling the reader what you did, rather tell us what you found or what your overriding message/s is/are. This is what we normally look forward to in Conclusions. 3. The title includes the word "rapid". Is it really necessary? How would it differ from a non-rapid review? Rather why not just say "A review…"? 4. As the study expands to COVID-19 prevention and control (as per the stated objective), in the introduction, it would be important refer to pandemic mitigation strategies (nonpharmaceutical interventions) as outlined in the CDC document of 2007 or its revision 2017, detailed in the BMJ editorial(BMJ 2020; 368 doi: https://doi.org/10.1136/bmj.m1066 (Published 17 March 2020) and more detailed piece in IJID (https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijid.2020.06.049) 5. as mentioned in The title is ambitious

VERSION 1 – AUTHOR RESPONSE

Reviewer: 1
Dr. Javier Mariani, GEDIC (Grupo de Estudio, Docencia e Investigacion Clinica)
Comments to the Author:
Authors report a systematic review on the Find, Test, Trace, Isolation and Support (FTTIS) policies for

COVID-19 response.
The manuscript is extremely interesting, timely, and relevant because it summarizes all the information available on health systems strategies to respond to the pandemic, up to the time the literature search was performed. As the authors point out, this information could be useful for health planning. Furthermore, it is very clearly presented and comprehensive.
The main concern that arises when reviewing the paper is that the search was carried out on May 28, the date on which 160 articles were found. Repeating the search strategy, according to the search terms and the type of article reported by the authors, on December 22, 1,290 articles were retrieved only in PubMed, and this included papers from regions of the world not contemplated in the current manuscript. and new information on aspects addressed in the review.
Modifications in the epidemiological dynamics of the pandemic and in the adaptive responses of various regions of the world could enrich the knowledge for future measures, so it would be important to incorporate this new information into the review.
We thank the positive comments of the reviewer. The review focuses on the urgent response of the COVID-19 pandemic, and thus events during the first 6 months of the pandemic. As research articles published after May 2020 may include additional information on FTTIS during the urgent response, we supplement our search with a second systematic review discussing FTTIS strategies during the early phase of the COVID-19 pandemic published between June 2020 and January 2021. We have now revised the methods, results and discussion to include the additional literature.
Our search included studies from all regions of the world and the findings should be representative to the adaptive responses of different geoschemes.
Reviewer: 2
Dr. Ralf Reintjes, Hamburg University of Applied Sciences, Tampere University
Comments to the Author:
This is an interesting paper, even though it does not follow the standard structure of a research paper. Nevertheless, it is of interest for decision makers and the medical community.
The major point I need to raise is, that the paper does not provide a discussion of its limitations. Thus a comprehensive discussion part should be added.
We thank the reviewer for these positive comments. We have now included a discussion in the manuscript, including a summary of the main findings; strengths and limitation of the study and in relation to other studies, the significance and implications of the study for practitioners and policymakers; and unanswered questions for future research.
In the methods section I was wondering why the literature review was limited 1.) to English language as a lot of potentially useful document will be missed and 2.) why it was limited to papers published between May 2019 and May 2020.
Thank you for the comments and we made changes to the study accordingly.
1) We reviewed studies published in English thus enable the review team to cross-validate the results. Although information documented in other languages might be missed, our search included studies from all regions of the world and findings from the policy review might be robust to the limitation. We have included this as a limitation in the discussion of the study.
2) The review focuses on the urgent response of the COVID-19 pandemic, and thus the timeline covers its first 6 months. As research articles published after May 2020 may include additional information on FTTIS during the urgent response, we supplement our search with a second systematic review discussing FTTIS strategies during the early phase of the COVID-19 pandemic published between June 2020 and January 2021. We have now revised the method, results and discussion with the additional literature.
Minor points:
Page 3, line 37: correct to "NOT available"
Page 4, line 7: at current it is questionable if high-risk settings still holds.
Page 6, line 20/21: please correct the language
Page 6, lines 38-50: these measures are used in various countries, not only in those mentioned, and often a combination of these.

We have changed and edited the text accordingly.
Reviewer: 3
Dr. Shahul Ebrahim, University of Bamako
Comments to the Author:
Chung etal. A rapid systematic review….
A very useful and informative work on COVID-19 response. I comment the authors on undertaking this effort. Few suggestions to boost its readability from a customer's perspective.
1. I would suggest authors to reformat the abstract sections "Results" and "Conclusions" to provide some take home results and conclusions points for the reader. As it is written, for example the conclusion, "Results of the review may inform countries…" is not reassuring for the reader. Although the readers will ultimately weigh on what the authors are proposing, the authors should provide what they found and how it can impact policy. In the Results section of the abstract it says, "we reported optimal strategies to shorten….", rather a quick reader is looking for what exactly are those. Please remember, many readers would just read the abstract and decide if they want to read further. Therefore, make the bait in the abstract more inviting
.2. The above comment applies also to the conclusions in page 10. Rather than telling the reader what you did, rather tell us what you found or what your overriding message/s is/are. This is what we normally look forward to in Conclusions.
We thank the constructive comments of the reviewer. We have now included a discussion in the manuscript, including a summary of the main findings; strengths and limitation of the study and in relation to other studies, the significance and implications of the study for practitioners and policymakers; and unanswered questions for future research. We also revise the abstract conclusions to make it more informative.
3. The title includes the word "rapid". Is it really necessary? How would it differ from a non-rapid review? Rather why not just say "A review…"?
We agree with the reviewer and have edit the title to clarify.
4. As the study expands to COVID-19 prevention and control (as per the stated objective), in the introduction, it would be important refer to pandemic mitigation strategies (nonpharmaceutical interventions) as outlined in the CDC document of 2007 or its revision 2017, detailed in the BMJ editorial(BMJ 2020; 368 doi:
https://eur01.safelinks.protection.outlook.com/?url=https%3A%2F%2Fdoi.org%2F10.1136%2Fbmj.m1066&data=04%7C01%7C%7C8a946cde7954414ecee108d8b93b9a44%7C1faf88fea9984c5b93c9210a11d9a5c2%7C0%7C0%7C637463012933356707%7CUnknown%7CTWFpbGZsb3d8eyJWIjoiMC4wLjAwMDAiLCJQIjoiV2luMzIiLCJBTiI6Ik1haWwiLCJXVCI6Mn0%3D%7C2000&sdata=FewSIIA4zSqarQgmGZJGcGnF%2B%2BGWmJGz%2FlBAuDoZTBE%3D&reserved=0 (Published 17 March 2020) and more detailed piece in IJID
(https://eur01.safelinks.protection.outlook.com/?url=https%3A%2F%2Fdoi.org%2F10.1016%2Fj.ijid.2020.06.049&data=04%7C01%7C%7C8a946cde7954414ecee108d8b93b9a44%7C1faf88fea9984c5b93c9210a11d9a5c2%7C0%7C0%7C637463012933356707%7CUnknown%7CTWFpbGZsb3d8eyJWIjoiMC4wLjAwMDAiLCJQIjoiV2luMzIiLCJBTiI6Ik1haWwiLCJXVCI6Mn0%3D%7C2000&sdata=Po%2FSSIGiE69qe%2F8l%2F%2BzUubBHxX3OTpvE5bViHAB08As%3D&reserved=0)
We agree with the reviewer and have cited the studies.
5. as mentioned in The title is ambitious
We agree with the reviewer and have edit the title accordingly.